

TSANGAI BUSINESS GROWTH SERIES · #07

The Business Systems Checklist

The eight systems every service business needs to run without the owner — and a 20-minute way to build the one you're missing.

WHO IT'S FOR

Owners who ARE the system —
where everything lives in their head

TIME REQUIRED

15 minutes

WHAT YOU'LL ACHIEVE

Your weakest system identified —
and your first SOP written by AI
today

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

If it lives in your head, it's not a system. It's a liability.

This checklist rates the eight systems every service business runs on. You'll find your weakest one, then use AI to turn what's in your head into a written system — in about 20 minutes.

Here's the test I give every owner: could you take two weeks off with your phone off? If the answer makes you laugh, you don't have a business yet — you have a very demanding job. The gap between those two things is systems. And with AI, writing them down is now the easy part.

— Ray, TsangAI Consulting

WHY THIS MATTERS

8

Core systems that run a service business
— most owners have 2 written down

20 min

Time to turn one process from "in my head" to a written SOP with AI

2 wks

The vacation test: could the business run without you for two weeks?

THE ONE IDEA

Talk it out. Let AI write it down.

The reason your processes aren't documented isn't laziness — it's that writing is slow. So don't write. Explain the task out loud like you're training a new hire, record it, and let AI turn the transcript into a clean step-by-step SOP.

Example: An HVAC owner spent years "meaning to" document his estimate process. He voice-recorded himself explaining it on a drive between jobs — nine minutes. AI turned it into a two-page SOP with a checklist. His new tech quoted his first job solo that same week.

YOUR 10-MINUTE QUICK WIN

- ☐ Score all eight systems on the checklist on page 4
- ☐ Circle your lowest row — that's the system costing you most
- ☐ Record a voice memo explaining that process like you're training someone
- ☐ Paste the transcript into the SOP prompt on page 4 — done, it's documented

Five steps from "in my head" to "on paper"

1 Score the eight systems

For each system, three questions: Is it written down? Does someone besides you own it? Is any part automated? One point each.

Do this: Fill in the checklist on page 4. Total each row out of 3.

2 Pick ONE system — your weakest that hurts

Lowest score wins. Tie-breaker: which one would break first if you took two weeks off?

Do this: Circle one row. Ignore the other seven for now.

3 Record yourself doing or explaining it

Voice memo, phone screen recording, or a Loom while you do the task. Talk like you're training a smart new hire. Ten minutes max.

Do this: Record it today — perfection is the enemy, rambling is fine.

4 Let AI turn it into an SOP

Paste the transcript into the SOP Builder prompt on page 4. You'll get numbered steps, a checklist, and the common failure points — in seconds.

Do this: Run the prompt, read it once, fix anything AI got wrong.

5 Store it where the team actually looks

One home for all SOPs: Google Drive folder, Notion page, wherever your team already lives. A system nobody can find doesn't exist.

Do this: Create the folder, drop in SOP #1, and tell the team where it lives.

COMMON MISTAKES

This is where most business owners get stuck.

They try to document all eight systems in one heroic weekend — and burn out by Sunday. They write SOPs nobody can find. And they document the process but never hand it to anyone, so they're still the bottleneck.

PRO TIP

Make it a rhythm: one system per week, recorded on your commute or between jobs. In eight weeks you'll have a business that runs on paper instead of memory — that's what buyers pay premiums for, and what lets you finally take that vacation.

The checklist + the SOP Builder prompt

The 8-System Checklist W = Written · O = Owned by someone else · A = Partly automated

SYSTEM	WHAT IT COVERS	W	O	A	/3
1. Lead capture	How enquiries come in and get logged	☐	☐	☐	___
2. Sales & quoting	Follow-up, quotes, closing the job	☐	☐	☐	___
3. Client onboarding	Welcome, intake, kickoff, expectations	☐	☐	☐	___
4. Service delivery	How the actual work gets done, start to finish	☐	☐	☐	___
5. Billing & collections	Invoices, payments, chasing late payers	☐	☐	☐	___
6. Marketing	Content, reviews, referrals — how leads are created	☐	☐	☐	___
7. Hiring & training	Finding, interviewing, and ramping new people	☐	☐	☐	___
8. Reporting	The numbers you check weekly to steer the business	☐	☐	☐	___

The SOP Builder Prompt

You are an operations manager for a **[WHAT YOU DO]** business. Below is a transcript of me explaining how we do: **[TASK NAME]**. Turn it into an SOP a brand-new hire could follow with zero questions: 1) numbered steps in order, 2) tools or logins needed at each step, 3) a "done right looks like" checklist, 4) the 3 most likely mistakes and how to avoid them. Keep it under one page. Transcript: **[PASTE TRANSCRIPT]**

The Vacation Test

- ✓ Could a new hire find how we do this in under 2 minutes?
- ✓ Would this process survive me being unreachable for 2 weeks?
- ✓ Does someone other than me own the outcome?
- ✓ If they left tomorrow, is the knowledge still in the business?

Any "no" above = that system still depends on a person, not a process.

Turn this guide into one win this week.

A guide you read changes nothing. A page you fill in does. Two minutes — do it while it's fresh.

1 • WHERE I AM TODAY

My weakest system: _____

Voice memo recorded? ☐

2 • THE ONE THING I'M FIXING THIS WEEK

My one fix: _____

The first small step (under 15 minutes): _____

Small beats big. Pick something you can finish in one sitting.

3 • WHEN I'M DOING IT

Day: _____ Time: _____ Booked in my calendar? ☐

Open your calendar and book it now — a plan without a time slot is a wish.

4 • AFTER — WHAT HAPPENED

My result (hours saved, jobs booked, thing shipped): _____

What I'll do differently next time: _____

NOTES

KEEP THE STREAK

One fix a week is 52 upgrades a year. When this page is full, re-take the guide — a rising score is proof your systems are working.